No state had also witnessed the kind of tumult in the previous two decades as UP had. Stretching back to the demolition of the Babri Masjid in 1991 and the rise of Mulayam Singh and Mayawati, UP had been the cauldron in which the politics of caste and community were playing out in their most ugly form through this period. With a population of nearly 200 million—UP would have been the world's sixth largest country if it had been independent—poor, overpopulated, badly governed and riddled with socio-political conflict, it was a microcosm of the larger crisis confronting the Indian state. In the absence of large-scale industry and employment, politics remains UP's biggest *udyog* (industry). Every inch of that fertile Gangetic soil is intensely politicized.

As a journalist, I had a ringside view of politics as raw theatre in Uttar Pradesh. I had watched mikes being thrown by MLAs in the state assembly, a chief minister being sworn in for just a day at midnight, Mayawati being manhandled by Samajwadi Party MLAs (she later claimed they had wanted to rape and kill her), and heard gory stories of criminal MLAs taking *supari*s (contracts) to kill their rivals. For a political journalist, there was no place like UP to observe the turbulence of Indian politics (well, OK, Bihar under Lalu too!). As I would tell my school friends in distant south Mumbai, 'If you want to understand India and Indian politics, spend some time travelling through UP and Bihar.'

What had also become clear in this period of flux in UP was the decline of the national parties. The Congress had struggled to retain its relevance post-1989 when Rajiv Gandhi's government was defeated. 'You want to meet a real Congressman in UP? Look for a senior citizen who has been sleeping for the last twenty years!' was how one journalist once described the state of the party to me.

The BJP had built its cadres in UP on the back of the contentious Ram Janmabhoomi agitation, attempting to fill the vacuum left behind by the shrinking Congress. It seemed to work. But only for a short while. Soon, the 'Hindu' vote bank that the party had tried to consolidate realized that they were being taken for one giant ride. No mandir was going to come up in the near future. It was only an electoral ploy to garner votes. By contrast,